

BILLIONAIRE BOULEVARD

With the Ambanis and Birlas moving into Cumballa Hill, it promises to become the country's toniest neighbourhood



■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Captain Ashok Batra, a snow-bearded retired merchant navy officer still remembers Altamount Road as it was in 1981, when he first moved in. The legendary J.R.D. Tata lived next door in his stately colonial bungalow, The Cairn. "You could walk down the quiet leafy avenue on Cumballa Hill without being run over by a car," he smiles. The trees are still there and the winding roller-coaster road which continues as Carmichael Road on the hillcrest, is still relatively quiet. But now, the rumble of construction from across the road signifies that life for most of the denizens of this lesser-known cousin of Malabar Hill, will never be the same.

Like a giant Wellsian tripod from the *War of the Worlds*, Mukesh Ambani's private skyscraper, Antilia, is rising from a 4,000-sq m plot above the towers of the vertical city. Over 500 labourers, working in 12-hour shifts, have already completed 17 of the total 24 storeys. With an area of over 6-lakh sq ft, this steel, glass and concrete structure will have more floor space than the Palace of



Photographs by BHASKAR PAUL



THE AMBANIS Antilia

This Rs 4,000 crore skyscraper rises from a 4,000-sq m plot. Seventeen of the 24 storeys are complete. This steel, glass and concrete structure will have helipads, health clubs, gardens, a swimming pool and a movie theatre.